

Lab Guide: Installing and Launching Nessus on Windows

Objective

Instructions to install and configure the Nessus vulnerability scanner on a Windows 10 or 11 system. By the end of these instructions, you will have a working vulnerability scanner accessible via a web interface.

Prerequisites

- Windows 10 or Windows 11 system
- Local Administrator privileges
- Internet connection
- Ability to download installers from Tenable's website
- Browser access (Edge, Chrome, or Firefox)

Step 1 — Download the Nessus Installer

Nessus for Windows must be downloaded directly from Tenable.

1. Open a web browser and navigate to:

<https://www.tenable.com/downloads/nessus>

2. Select **Nessus**.
3. Under **Choose Your Platform**, select **Windows (x64)**.
4. Click **Download** to save the `.msi` installer.
5. Wait for the download to complete before moving to the next step.

Step 2 — Run the Installer

1. Navigate to your **Downloads** folder.
2. Double-click the Nessus `.msi` installer file.
3. When Windows asks for permission, click **Yes**.

The Nessus Setup Wizard will appear.

4. Click **Next**.
5. Accept the **License Agreement**, then click **Next**.
6. Select the default installation directory unless instructed otherwise.

7. Click **Install**.

Installation may take several minutes.

8. When installation is complete, click **Finish**.

Step 3 — Start the Nessus Service

After installation, Nessus installs a Windows service named **Tenable Nessus**.

To confirm it is running:

1. Press **Windows + R**.

2. Type:

`services.msc`

3. Press **Enter**.

4. Scroll to **Tenable Nessus**.

5. Ensure the status is **Running** and the startup type is **Automatic**.

If it is not running:

6. Right-click **Tenable Nessus** → **Start**.

Step 4 — Access the Nessus Web Interface

Nessus is managed through a browser-based interface.

1. Open your preferred web browser.

2. Navigate to:

`https://localhost:8834`

Because Nessus uses a self-signed certificate, a warning will appear.

3. Click **Advanced** → **Proceed to localhost (unsafe)**.

You should now see the Nessus initialization page.

Step 5 — Configure Nessus

1. On the welcome page, select **Nessus Essentials**.

2. Enter your **name** and **email address**.

3. Check your email for the Nessus **activation code**.

4. Enter the activation code.

5. Create an admin username and password.

Nessus will then begin downloading and compiling plugins.

Step 6 — Nessus Plugin Initialization

Nessus now downloads and initializes thousands of plugins.

This stage can take ****10–30 minutes****, depending on internet speed.

Students must wait until the process fully completes before proceeding.

During this phase, Nessus will display:

- Downloading Plugins
- Compiling Plugins
- Initializing Nessus...

Step 7 — Log In and Launch Nessus

Once initialization completes:

1. The Nessus login screen will load.
2. Enter the admin credentials you created.

You now have access to:

- Scan templates
- Policies
- Reports
- Plugin tools

Students may now begin creating vulnerability scans as instructed.

Completion

Students have successfully installed and launched Nessus on Windows. Nessus is now ready for use in vulnerability scanning labs, security assessments, and reporting exercises.